

DIFFICULTIES FACED BY PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES (PWD)

Introduction

It is estimated that about one billion people or 15% of the world's population experience some form of disability according to the United Nations. Prevalence is higher in developing countries and as many as 40 to 50 million are from India. Persons with disability are subject to a lot of hurdles and impediments in different areas of their life that hamper their full participation and enjoyment of rights in life. They experience adverse problems compared to people with no disability. Even within this group, there are some of them who are more vulnerable to hardships and obstacles due to their age, gender and severity of their disability. This unit therefore shall be focussed on the issues and challenges of PWDs and specific concerns of the vulnerable groups.

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PWD form the world's largest minority group who encounter challenges in all spheres of their life. Inaccessible physical environments and transportations, non-availability of aids and assistive devices, and facing negative attitudes in society are some of the day to day problems faced.

They are looked at with pity and sympathy which further poses difficulties for them to make efforts to lead a fulfilled life. Many a times they are considered a burden and a liability to family and society at large. The challenges faced by them are discussed herein.

- **Individual level**

Disability is considered as a human rights issue and also a development issue which has huge ramifications in the person's life. An individual with disability foremost needs to come to terms or acceptance of his or her state if they are in a position to comprehend what is happening. People with physical disabilities will be able to understand their situation and be part of any intervention or rehabilitation measure. But those with mental illness, severe mental retardation or any kind of trauma wherein they are unable to think rationally will not even know they are different and have challenges that need to be addressed. Therefore, it becomes an uphill task for their families and caregivers. Mental health conditions are particularly stigmatized. People with mental health conditions face discrimination even in health care settings. On the other hand, if we examine disability in general, it leaves a big impact in an individual's life, affecting all areas of their functioning – health, education, employment, finances, family, social and cultural life. Apart from facing impediments in these areas, they are also subject to social stigma and discrimination and subject to multiple deprivations. Negative attitudes and behaviours have an adverse effect on children and adults with disabilities, leading to negative consequences such as low self-esteem and reduced participation. People who feel harassed because of their disability sometimes avoid going to places, changing their routines, or even moving from their homes. They live isolated lives, sometimes completely dependent on caregivers even for fulfilment of their basic needs. Many a times, they are not even considered as people who have the same rights entitled to everyone. Policies have been formulated and legislations have been passed in the country to ensure that people with disabilities are cared for and protected and their rights are upheld so that they live a life of dignity and self-respect. But still, there's a long way to go to make it a reality where every person with disability in a developing country like India is able to live a fully productive life.

- **In day to day activities**

Managing daily activities for a person with disability and those who live with them is not an easy task. The family also goes through physical, financial and psychological stress to assist the disabled person. Especially when it is severe disability and they are totally dependent on the caregiver to fulfil all their basic needs. Eating, bathing, dressing, toiletry, mobility etc are some of the most essential activities

that may need assistance. Some of them may require medical care on a daily basis too which needs to be looked into. Others may not need any assistance to help them with fulfilling basic needs, but will they be able to cook, shop, clean house, go to work, manage finances and transportation are some of the aspects that are to be considered. The financial status of the PWD also plays a crucial role in enabling the person meet all the daily needs and carry on their activities. Assisted technology may be needed for people to be fully involved in daily activities independently, such as aids that help in travel, to communicate, devices like special computers that helps them to communicate, wheelchairs, walkers, scooters that help in their mobility.

- **Education**

Children with disabilities (CWD) are ten time less likely to be out of school than other kids (Plan International) and 90% do not attend school (UNESCO). Global adult literacy rate is low as 3% (UNDP). Low rates of enrolment in schools and even if they join school, drop out at early stage even before they reach secondary level. Sometimes, they are placed in special schools or in residential institutions away from family in order to be educated. There are many barriers that prevent them from availing education.

Some specific challenges in education system are:

- Lack of funds - Special education demand increased budgets that hinder education at the higher levels.
- Accessibility – physical barriers to attend school/college etc. (lack of ramps, elevators, inaccessible washrooms, school buildings etc)
- Discrimination – they are subject to bullying, violence, stigmatised and ridiculed by students, educators and staff.
- Lack of inclusive education –no inclusion of children with mild/moderate disabilities in regular schools. Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan has made an effort to promote the inclusion of children with disabilities, the system faces a lot of challenges in identifying these children as well as responding to their needs.
- Lack of special schools – no trained special educators or educational materials.

- **Employment and Societal level**

Being deprived of quality or basic education, PWDs face yet another major challenge of getting employed. In spite of many of them being capable of working efficiently, they are unable to find employers who are willing to recruit someone with disabilities. In India, out of 70 million PWDs, only about 100,000 have been able to get a job. Public sector hardly recruits them even though 4 % reservation is allocated as per the Right to Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. It is difficult for them to develop employable skills and gaining meaningful employment. There is also lack of access to resources to promote self-employment and other livelihood opportunities. Even in situations where they are employed in unorganised sectors, there is possibility of exploitation and abuse, they are paid very less for the work they accomplish. Negative attitudes prevail among colleagues which can result in discrimination. Chances of employment is even worse when it comes to people with multiple or severe disabilities. Disabled People's Organisations are very essential to address these issues and advocate for amicable work environments for PWD.

At the societal level, there is social exclusion of the disabled; they face discrimination every day of their lives, be it in educational institutions, workplace, transportation or in cultural life. People with mental retardation/mental illness are ridiculed and stigmatised which further leads to social exclusion. They or their families keep themselves aloof from any social gatherings or programmes. PWD also find it a challenge depending on the type of disability to participate in social get togethers or attend religious places of worship.

- **Other Allied Problems/Conditions**

PWDs face other obstacles and hurdles in their life such as:

- Health issues – PWDs have lack of access to or not part of immunisation, health screening, lack of aids and appliances, proper health check-up, monitoring, continuation of medications (for physical or mental illness/symptoms) etc.
- Accessibility –accessibility cuts across many aspects ranging from physical accessibility in buildings, transportation to access to health services, welfare schemes, etc for their development.
- Violence –PWDs are subject to physical, emotional or sexual abuse in families, institutions or in society. Those in long term hospitalisation are likely to be mistreated by health workers and they unable to defend themselves in all situations.
- Poverty – increases the risk of disability through inadequate access to health care, education, life skills training, safe work places, aids and appliances, safe water and sanitation etc.
- Lack of awareness – of government welfare schemes and programmes, scholarships, etc thereby less scope for rehabilitation or mainstreaming in society.

VULNERABLE PWDs

Majority of people with disabilities find it very difficult to simply survive and lead lives as they desire. They are very vulnerable due to the different barriers they face such as attitudinal, physical and financial. There are many special groups with disabilities that can be categorised as vulnerable and need specialised care and support when we examine the total population of PWD. Women, children, people with multiple and severe difficulties are some of them who shall be discussed in this section. Apart from that, other groups who are also vulnerable are the elderly who develop conditions such as arthritis, strokes, deterioration in hearing and seeing; victims of any crime who are disabled, disabled refugees or migrant workers. These groups face discrimination owing to their situation and status and having a disability further exacerbates their condition, making it very difficult to adapt and survive.

• Women with Disabilities

Women with disabilities are the most disadvantaged and marginalised group experiencing exclusion owing to their gender and disability. There are 11,824,355 women with disabilities constituting 44.09 percent of total disabled population in India (Census, 2011). They are subject to varied hardships which impede on their access to essential services such as health care, education, vocational rehabilitation and employment. They experience inequality in living, access to credit, and rarely participate in economic decision making. Women and girls with disabilities are more vulnerable to all forms of abuse and exploitation, some of them even in their own homes have been beaten up, some are even forcibly sterilized. There have been many incidents of violations of their rights, neglect and maltreatment.

The Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities strongly stresses on the need for special protection to women with disabilities and calls upon the governments to take all measures to ensure the full development and empowerment of this marginalised group so that they enjoy their human rights and fundamental freedom.

• Children with Disabilities

Disabled children are the most vulnerable group and need special attention. It is estimated that globally 93 to 150 million children experience some form of disability (WHO) and 2.04 million children with disabilities in the country in India (Census, 2011). Children are born with disabilities; some develop after birth and others due to any injury or accident. They are less likely to attend school,

thereby they have limited opportunities for employment and productive life in adulthood. Only around two percent of the disabled children are able to attend school. For children to have an impairment, it can lead to rejection or isolation from any activity or experience that is part of normal child development. Supportive families and community are essential for them during this time. Even if inclusive education is advocated for, very few children are integrated into the system and most of the educational institutions do not have trained teachers to provide the requisite educational support to these children with mild or moderate levels of disability and can be trained. Availability of special schools for the visually impaired, hearing and speech impaired children is also very less and many families are unable to financially afford them as a result of which such children are just left behind. Poverty is a major hurdle that stands in the way of these children accessing schools. Research states that violence against children with disabilities is 1.7 times greater compared to children without disabilities.

The Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC), 1989 is the first international treaty that has a specific reference to children with disability stating that they should not be discriminated and shall enjoy a full and decent life with dignity and also participate in matters relating to them. The Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities also lay emphasis on governments to ensure that children with disabilities have full enjoyment of all human rights and fundamental freedom on par with other children and their best interest should be of prime importance. They should be cared for, protected and have all opportunities for development, grow up in enabling environments and have access to education, health, vocational training and specialized rehabilitation services.

- **Persons with Multiple Disabilities**

Multiple disabilities refer to a combination of two or more serious disabilities. 8% (21.16 lakhs) of the disabled in India have multiple disabilities (Census, 2011). It can be defined as including more than one impairment, the combination of which causes severe educational needs that cannot be accommodated in a programme that caters only for one of the impairments. These conditions make learning and instructions complex. They are slow to make progress and can only grasp slowly with practice and repetition. Problems with muscle movement, understanding, hearing and seeing can be there which makes it difficult for them to commute and also communicate. It is crucial that proper assessment is made of the kind of disability the person has so that immediate interventions can be carried out. Multiple disabilities can be due to traumatic brain injury, genetic disorder, premature birth or chromosomal abnormality. Individual can be affected to a great extent that they need special care to address their developmental and educational needs and some of them may require lifelong support.

Examples of multiple disabilities are:

- Deaf blind (Visual Impairment + Hearing Impairment)
- Visual Impairment + Hearing Impairment + Mental Retardation
- Visual Impairment + Mental Retardation
- Cerebral Palsy + Mental Retardation/ Hearing/ Speech/ Visual problems

The National Institute for Empowerment of Persons with Multiple Disabilities (Divyangjan) has been established by the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities, Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Government of India as a national resource center in Chennai, Tamil Nadu, for empowering those with multiple disabilities.

- **Persons with Severe and Profound Disability**

Persons who require extensive lifelong support to manage their daily life are termed as those with severe disabilities. Fred Orelve and Dick Sobsey defined this group as persons with mental retardation who require extensive or pervasive support and also possess one or more significant motor

or sensory impairments or special health needs. There can be two or more of these characteristics: restriction of movement, skeletal deformities, sensory disorders, seizure disorders, lung and breathing control, or other medical problems such as such as skin breakdown or bladder infections. They are the most vulnerable among disabled population, they are dependant on others to fulfil their basic physical needs and may require care giving support all the time.

Actually, both these groups of persons with multiple or disabilities are identified at an early stage in life due to significant developmental delays or their physical abnormalities.